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Bolt from the blue

Andy Coates on how a restless mind inspired this nut and bolt box

This project was born out of two things: boredom and observation. During a large batch run of spindles the mind can wander. In fact, batch turning anything is not the most interesting thing for me. Once the brain and muscles have got into the routine, it's easy to let them do the work on autopilot while you consider the problems of the world – what to make for dinner, perhaps, or whether it makes any sense to buy that new super-duper tool. Other turners, of course, may feel differently about batch work.

It was during one of these sessions, mind wandering where it would, that I think I actually noticed for the first time what a pleasing shape the transition from the square to the round, the pommel, can be. When cut cleanly with a skew it's a lovely shape. But we usually only see it one-sided. I wondered what it might look like as a two-sided shape. Surely it would be nice...

At the next opportunity to experiment I mounted a square of oak (*Quercus robur*) and had a play. As a two-sided shape it seemed to have possibilities, but for what? After some more playing I decided to lop off the corners from the resulting square flange. It created four leaf-shaped lozenges which could prove ideal for decorating, so that might be an option. But it was then that, to my eye, it began to resemble a nut. A stylised four-sided nut, but a nut all the same. As I had the skew already in hand I cut some fake threads to the right and left of the 'nut' and there was the basis of an odd little box.

The first ones I made were from square stock, the corners knocked off the 'nut' section to create a stylised form. It seemed to work. So I made a box. As very little I do escapes the torture of the pyrography machine I decided to add some interest with a little design on the lid section. In a flash I had the design. Anybody around my age will remember the company name 'ACME' from American cartoons, and ACME seemed perfect for this object – and that's when the ACME Nut & Bolt Co box was truly born. Welcome to the world you little novelty you!

Since then I have refined the idea slightly, and progressed to actually cutting the blank into a hexagon prior to turning. While the square version does work, the hexagonal version is far better. As with most boxes, the one-third top/two-thirds base section proportion works best, but for simplicity and ease of explanation I have used a 50/50 design here. You might decide to make yours to any proportion you like, the process is the same, only the dimensions will alter, and they should be easily arrived at.

Decorating the top as I do here is entirely personal. You may wish to leave the top plain, or decorate it in another fashion.

As ever I haven't specified lathe speeds. As a general rule of thumb the lathe speed should be as fast as is appropriate for your experience, comfort and safety. If you think it looks too fast, then it probably is. During abrading always reduce the lathe speed to about 500-600 RPM.

ANDY COATES

Andy is on the Register of Professional Turners (RPT) and is Chairman of the AWGB. He is a professional woodturner and has a workshop and gallery in Suffolk. He mostly makes one-off pieces, but like any jobbing woodturner, is just as likely to be found doing small batch runs, antique restorations or any number of strange commissions. He also demonstrates and teaches turning.

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